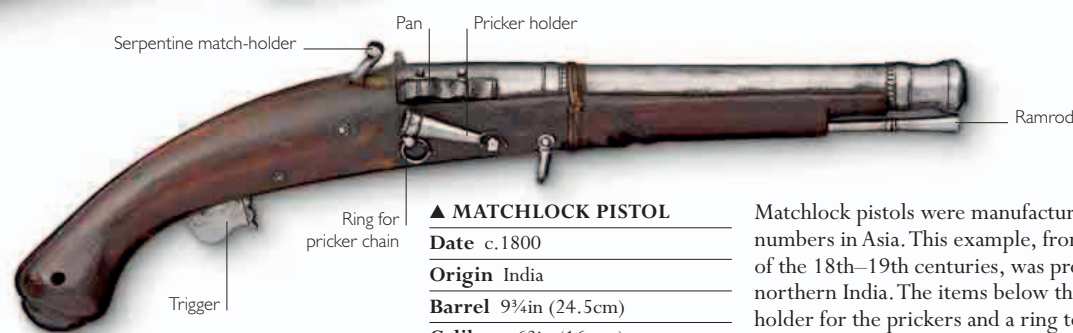
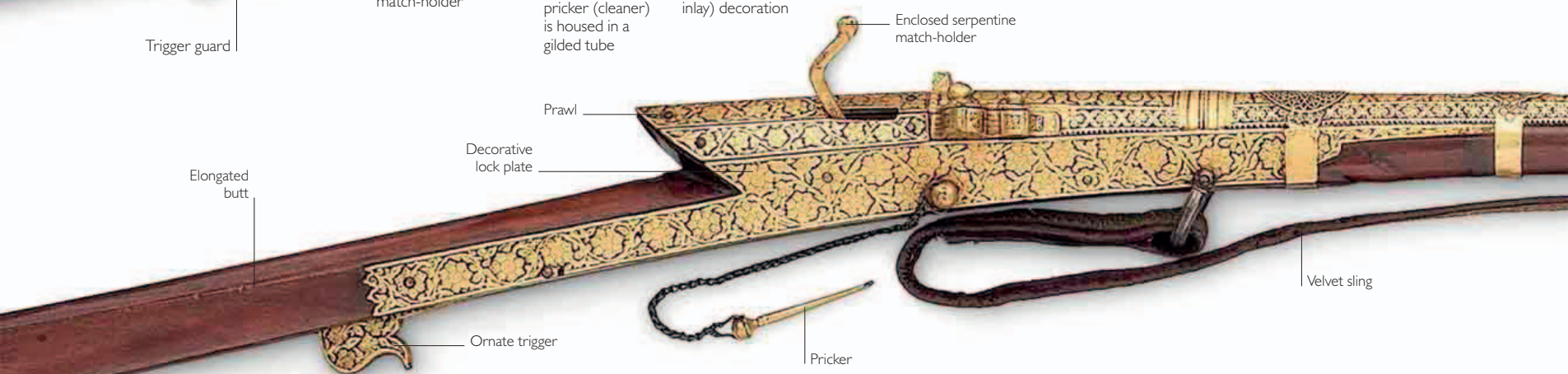
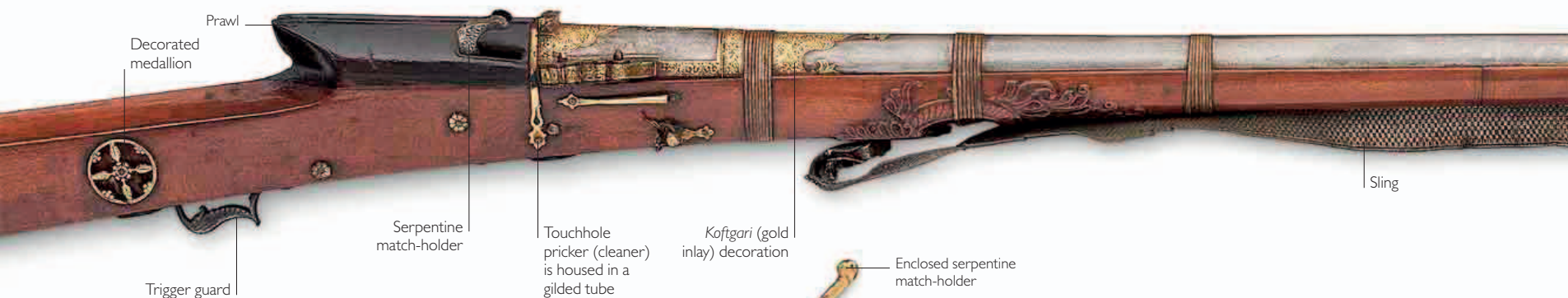


ASIAN FIREARMS (1781–1830)

In Asia, guns remained technically simple for more than 500 years. The matchlock mechanism used, similar to that in Europe, persisted well into the late 19th century. While the snap-matchlock mechanism was used in Japan (see p.72), in India and elsewhere in Asia, gunmakers commonly employed the squeeze-type matchlock. This type of matchlock was concealed almost fully within the stock. The serpentine was linked to a trigger bar, which released it when a user pulled the trigger. In India, the guns varied between regions in the form of their stocks, and in their chiseled and gilded decoration. Matchlock pistols were made only in Asia, while people in Europe were using pistols driven by flintlocks and wheel-locks—mechanisms that would reach some parts of Asia only later and never be used in other parts.



▲ MATCHLOCK PISTOL

Date c.1800

Origin India

Barrel 9¾in (24.5cm)

Caliber .63in (16mm)

Matchlock pistols were manufactured in small numbers in Asia. This example, from the turn of the 18th–19th centuries, was produced in northern India. The items below the pan are a holder for the prickers and a ring to which its chain was attached.

